

# A QUILT EXPLAINED

The terms patchwork and quilting are very often confused with one another. Patchwork usually refers to piecing, or sewing, pieces of fabric put together to make a larger, more intricate, piece of fabric. The

quilting is the stitches that hold the three layers of a quilt together. Read below to find out more about how a quilt comes together and its different elements.

## ► THE FIVE ELEMENTS OF A QUILT

There are five main elements needed to complete a quilt. The first element is a finished quilt top, often made of patchwork or appliqué. Your quilt top can be assembled using a repeating block pattern or several different blocks, such as in the diagram. You can also add sashing and borders (see pp.78–83) to either make the quilt fit a specific dimension or enhance the design.

The second element is wadding. Most quilters prefer to use 100 per cent cotton wadding or a 50/50 blend of cotton and silk, or cotton and bamboo. See pages 22–23 for more information on waddings.

The third element is the backing, which needs to be larger than both the quilt top and the wadding. A quilt back can be made of a single print or pattern, or it can be pieced just like the top. Very often several pieces of fabric will need to be joined to make a large enough backing for a quilt (see p.45).

The fourth element is quilting. Quilting is a very important part of a quilt and has a double duty. The main purpose is to hold all three layers of the quilt (the “quilt sandwich”) together securely. The second purpose is to create texture. The more a project is quilted, the more stiff it will become. A loose stitched pattern will give the quilt more softness. Quilting can either be done by hand or machine (see pp.130–133, 134–137).

The fifth and final part of a quilt is the binding. The binding is a strip of fabric sewn around the perimeter of the quilt to enclose the raw edges (see pp.46–51). A traditional binding should be finished at the back by hand. This method will give the quilt a professional finish.

### QUILT SANDWICH

The term “quilt sandwich” refers to the three basic layers in a quilt: the backing, wadding, and quilt top. Starting with the backing and quilt top as the bottom and top layers, the wadding is then placed between them to complete the sandwich. Once all of the layers have been stitched together, or quilted, the sandwich is squared up and the raw edges are enclosed with a binding.

